

The Phenomenal Confusion over Randomness

In all physical and informational systems, randomness is not chaos but structured potential, a space of possibilities shaped and constrained by the rules governing the system.

Randomness plays a central role across science, yet it remains one of the most misunderstood concepts. This document clarifies randomness through three lenses: information theory, algorithmic complexity, and quantum mechanics.

1. Randomness as Constrained Potential

Randomness is best understood not as disorder but as the constrained possibility space defined by a system's governing rules. Entropy measures this possibility space. The higher the entropy, the larger the set of allowable variations.

2. Shannon Entropy: Information and Constraint

In Shannon's formulation, entropy quantifies uncertainty. A system with higher entropy has more possible states. This does not mean chaos but rather a larger choice set. Randomness is potential structured by constraints such as channel capacity, noise levels, and encoding rules.

3. Algorithmic Complexity: Randomness as Incompressibility

Algorithmic randomness refers to sequences that cannot be compressed into shorter representations. A patternless sequence is one where no simplification exists. In this sense, randomness indicates maximal potential within the system's descriptive constraints.

4. Practical Example: Fraud Detection

In fraud detection, randomness takes the form of variation in transaction patterns. Most transactions fall into predictable clusters. Fraud introduces unexpected variations, outliers relative to the system's constraints. These variations reveal structure. Randomness exposes the edges of the model.

5. The Limits of Compressibility and Prediction: Determinism, Indeterminism, and Computational Irreducibility

Quantum events, such as radioactive decay, highlight profound limits on predictability. Whether these limits are truly fundamental, ontic, or reflect deep epistemic and computational barriers remains open. Stephen Wolfram has rigorously defended the principle of computational irreducibility. Many systems are structured such that their future states cannot be shortcut by any compressed description or prediction shorter than running the system itself.

In practice, we cannot distinguish, in principle for many cases, between a truly indeterministic world, a fully deterministic world whose rules are computationally irreducible or whose initial conditions or hidden variables are inaccessible, or a simulation running effective randomness.

Both strong determinism and strong indeterminism are currently unfalsifiable. What we observe are second-order effects: structured variation within constrained possibility spaces. The intuition that "more is going on than is obvious" persists, echoed in arguments like Roger Penrose's suggestion that consciousness and certain physical processes involve non-computable elements beyond current

formalisms. This situation echoes challenges elsewhere in science, such as the relationship between variation and selection in evolution where robust empirical patterns exist without a fully satisfying formal bridge. Such gaps do not invalidate the observable phenomena. Behavioral flexibility in biological systems remains a real, empirically attested feature. A certain comfort with the inherent messiness of biology, and complex systems more generally, is therefore warranted.

6. Randomness in Biology: From Bacteria to Brains

Biology offers some of the most vivid illustrations of randomness as structured potential. Across wildly different scales and organisms, from single-celled bacteria to insects navigating open space, evolution has not merely tolerated randomness but actively recruited it as a functional tool. Three examples illuminate this principle in complementary ways.

Quorum Sensing in Bacteria

Bacteria face a coordination problem. Acting alone is often futile, but acting collectively can reshape their environment. Quorum sensing is the mechanism by which bacterial populations gauge their own density and switch gene expression accordingly, triggering behaviors such as biofilm formation, bioluminescence, or the release of virulence factors only when sufficient numbers are present. What is less immediately obvious is the role randomness plays in this process. Individual bacteria exhibit stochastic variation in the expression of signaling molecules and receptor proteins, meaning that the threshold at which any given cell “commits” to a collective behavior is not fixed but probabilistically distributed across the population. This noise is not a flaw in the system. It functions as a hedge. By spreading the commitment threshold across individuals, the colony avoids catastrophic all-or-nothing failures and retains the capacity to respond flexibly to ambiguous or fluctuating environmental signals. The population-level outcome, coherent collective action, emerges from individual-level randomness operating within a tightly constrained chemical grammar. Entropy sets the stage. Quorum sensing makes the move.

Ant Foraging and the Random Walk

Foraging ants do not simply march in straight lines to food sources. Scout ants in many species perform exploratory walks whose direction changes are statistically random, or more precisely follow patterns known as Lévy flights, in which occasional long excursions are interspersed with tighter local searches. This is not aimless wandering. Mathematical analysis has shown that Lévy-type search strategies are close to optimal for locating sparsely distributed, unpredictably located resources in open environments. The randomness is structured. It operates within the constraints of the ant’s locomotor repertoire, chemical trail system, and the statistical geometry of the resource landscape. At the colony level, this individual-level stochasticity aggregates into swarm intelligence, a robust, adaptive foraging network that no single ant designed or directs. The colony’s coherent behavior is an emergent property of randomness operating under constraint. It is a living demonstration of Shannon’s insight that a larger, well-structured possibility space enables more powerful adaptation than a narrow, deterministic one.

Spontaneous Action and Behavioral Variability in Flies

Perhaps the most provocative biological evidence for the functional role of randomness comes from research on the fruit fly *Drosophila*. Neurobiologist Björn Brembs and colleagues have shown that fly behavior is substantially more variable than the noise in the sensory neurons driving it, meaning that the extra variability is not passive error but is actively generated by the brain. In controlled experiments where nothing in the environment changed, tethered flies continued to initiate spontaneous turning maneuvers, as if responding to stimuli that were not there. Analysis of the temporal structure of these movements revealed a nonlinear, non-random signature. The brain operates near a state of mathematical instability, exquisitely sensitive to tiny perturbations, which it amplifies into large-scale, unpredictable behavioral output. This is randomness used architecturally. The fly brain has evolved to sit at criticality, a regime where small fluctuations, whether from quantum processes, thermal noise, or internal circuit dynamics, are leveraged into genuine behavioral novelty. Predictability, for a fly evading a predator or solving a novel problem, is a liability. Structured unpredictability is the solution. Brembs frames this as the neurobiological basis of a scientific concept of free will: not metaphysical freedom, but the evolved capacity to generate genuinely novel actions rather than merely respond to stimuli. The dichotomy of determinism versus randomness dissolves. What remains is a brain doing something more interesting than either.

Taken together, these three examples share a common architecture. In each case, randomness is not noise to be filtered out but signal to be exploited. It operates within tight biological constraints, chemical, anatomical, evolutionary, and produces outcomes that are adaptive, coherent, and often computationally superior to what a purely deterministic system could achieve. Biology, it turns out, has been doing information theory all along.

7. Agency and Potential

Entropy sets the stage. Agency makes the move. Randomness supplies the possible trajectories, but systems, biological, artificial, or cultural, select from that space according to internal and external constraints.

Conclusion

Randomness is structured potential. It defines the possibility space within which adaptation, intelligence, and agency operate. An important side note is that consideration should be given to asymmetry as a necessary condition for existence and the role of Landauer treating information as a physical quantity. This is just one of a series of documents. Refer to the master index for an overview.